Aakansha Jain

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Education

Ph.D. in Economics, Iowa State University, USA — May 2027 (expected)

M.Sc. in Economics, Shiv Nadar University, India — 2020

B.Sc. in Economics, University of Calcutta, India — 2017

(Minor: Mathematics & Statistics; First-Class Honours)

Fields of Interest

Labor Economics, Agricultural Labor, Development Economics, Rural Development, Economics of Education, Migration, Applied Microeconomics

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

Manternach, R., **Jain, A.**, Orazem, P.F., & Soborowicz, L. (2025). "Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?" *Growth and Change*, 56(4): e70064.

Book Chapters

Jain, A., Montenegro, C., & Orazem, P.F. (forthcoming, 2026). "Youth Labor Markets in High- and Low-Income Countries." In K. Leicht (Ed.), *The Oxford Handbook of the 21st Century Economy and Society*. Oxford University Press.

Working Papers

"The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor"

Job Market Paper; solo-authored

Estimates how far H-2A guestworkers replaced the settled farm workforce lost to immigration enforcement. Certified H-2A positions grew more than fourfold between 2008 and 2024, while the settled non-citizen farm workforce shrank. Using a panel of 740 commuting zones and shift-share (Bartik) instruments built on national enforcement shocks, I show that farms hire approximately one H-2A guestworker for each settled worker lost, replacing about three quarters of the lost labor time. On the benchmark Border Patrol budget instrument, this substitution accounts for about 29 percent of H-2A growth since 2008.

"Returns to Farming with Controls for Farming Entry"

with I. Cho and P.F. Orazem; under review

Uses two surveys of Iowa State University alumni to study entry into farming and its relationship with household income. Parental farming, early work in a family business, and graduating into a weaker nonfarm labor market predict entry. Farmers have 33 to 38 percent lower household income than comparable nonfarm graduates across matching estimators, and about 35 percent lower in an endogenous treatment effects model. The gap is large and significant among nonrural farmers but not among rural farmers.

"College Wage Premiums in India: Trends and Spatial Decomposition, 1987–2012"

solo-authored

Traces the college wage premium across five waves of India's National Sample Survey, 1987–2012, a period when tertiary enrollment nearly tripled. The premium rose throughout, and zone-level decompositions show that the young–old premium gap closed where college supply expanded most.

"An Overview of the 2024 Iowa State University Alumni Survey"

with A. Andrade, J. Eyles, K. Kimle, P.F. Orazem, and R. Unal

Documents the design, sample construction, and descriptive findings of the 2024 Iowa State University alumni survey, covering graduating cohorts from 1982 to 2023 with over 5,000 usable responses. The primary data reference for subsequent work drawing on the survey.

Works in Progress

"Does Broadband Close the Rural Education Gap?"
with L. Han and J.V. Winters

Asks whether federally subsidized broadband raises college enrollment among rural high-school graduates. The Connect America Fund Phase II set block eligibility ex ante through an FCC cost model and deployed in stages over 2015–2021, leaving nearly half of eligible blocks unserved as controls. A staggered difference-in-differences design with block and cohort fixed effects links deployment records to restricted American Community Survey microdata.

"Firm Entry and Serial Entrepreneurship Among Iowa State Alumni"
with D. Lin and P.F. Orazem

Examines how labor market conditions at graduation shape entrepreneurial entry among Iowa State University alumni across the 2008 and 2024 alumni surveys. A higher Iowa unemployment rate at graduation delays business entry for about a decade, after which the effect fades; national conditions show no such effect. Over a full career, family and social ties to business ownership predict who becomes an entrepreneur.

Policy and Outreach Publications

- **Jain, A.**, & Chandio, R. (2026). "H-2A Compensation in Iowa: Trends, Policies, and Takeaways." *Ag Decision Maker*, October 2026. Iowa State University Extension and Outreach.
- **Jain, A.**, Lin, D., & Orazem, P.F. (forthcoming, Nov 2026). "Graduating in a Downturn: Business Cycles and Entrepreneurship Among Iowa State Graduates." *Agricultural Policy Review*, Fall 2026. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.
- **Jain, A.**, & Chandio, R. (forthcoming, Nov 2026). "Who Hires H-2A Workers in Iowa, and for What?" *Agricultural Policy Review*, Fall 2026. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.
- Crespi, G., & **Jain, A.** (2026). "Where Do They Go? Migration Patterns of Iowa State University Alumni." *Agricultural Policy Review*, Winter 2026. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.
- Andrade, A., Eyles, J., **Jain, A.**, Kimle, K., Orazem, P.F., & Unal, R. (2025). "How a Land Grant College Affects Business and Job Creation." *Agricultural Policy Review*, Fall 2025. Center for Agricultural and Rural Development, Iowa State University.

Public Engagement

Media Mentions

- "Iowa State college graduates left for bigger cities, but they're returning to Iowa." *Axios Des Moines*, April 21, 2026. Coverage of Crespi and Jain (2026).

Outreach Writing

- **Jain, A.** (2024). "How to Compute Real Income or Real Value of a Given Currency?" *Ask an Economist* (public question-and-answer column), Department of Economics, Iowa State University, November 6, 2024.

Conferences and Presentations

- "The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor." Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting, Houston, TX, November 2026.
- "The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor." Agricultural and Applied Economics Association (AAEA) South Asia Section Graduate Student Symposium (virtual), October 2026.
- Invited talk on how our first-place Data Visualization Challenge team used FAME data (with A. Basha and H. Lee). USDA Agricultural Marketing Service FAME 2.0 Release Webinar (virtual), October 2026.

- "The Rise of H-2A: Causal Evidence on Guestworker Substitution for Settled Farm Labor." AAEA Annual Meeting, Kansas City, MO, July 2026.
- "Mapping the Missing Market Pathways in U.S. Dairy Regions" (with A. Basha and H. Lee). Data Visualization Challenge, AAEA Annual Meeting, Kansas City, MO, July 2026.
- "Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?" (with R. Manternach, P.F. Orazem, and L. Soborowicz; presented by A. Jain). Midwest Economics Association Annual Meeting, Chicago, IL, March 2025.

Research Experience

Research Assistant, Iowa State University

Department of Economics (multiple appointments) Spring 2024 – Present

- Built the data pipeline for the 2024 Iowa State University Alumni Survey from raw Qualtrics responses, with Peter F. Orazem (Summer 2024).
- Constructed rural–urban migration measures across alumni graduating cohorts (Summer 2025).
- Analyze alumni entrepreneurship and the returns to farming as a quarter-time research assistant (Fall 2026).
- Write agricultural extension articles on H-2A hiring with Rabail Chandio (Fall 2026).
- Contributed to the empirical analysis of "Are College Towns Really Recession Proof?" (*Growth and Change*, 2025) and supported the undergraduate researchers on the project (Spring 2024).

Research Assistant, India

Indian School of Business, Hyderabad Summer 2022

- Contributed to a pilot randomized controlled trial evaluating India's food-subsidy program (the Public Distribution System) in the state of Bihar; managed survey logistics and data cleaning.

IFMR LEAD (development research center) Aug 2021 – Mar 2022

- Analyzed differential impacts of COVID-19 on the mental well-being of men and women using difference-in-differences; conducted data analysis in Stata and geocoding with the Google Maps API. Principal investigators: Amrita Dhillon and Sanchari Roy (King's College London) and Farzana Afridi (Indian Statistical Institute, Delhi).

King's College London (project based in India) Jun 2020 – Jul 2021

- Developed composite measures of Indian states' performance under two national programs, the rural employment guarantee (MGNREGA) and the rural roads program (PMGSY); supervised a team of research assistants for quality control of a large administrative dataset. Principal investigators: Amrita Dhillon (King's College London), Farzana Afridi (Indian Statistical Institute, Delhi), and Arka Roy Chaudhury (Shiv Nadar University).

Teaching Experience

Standalone Instructor, Iowa State University

ECON 3530: Money, Banking, and Financial Institutions Spring 2025

- Designed and delivered a full-semester course for 60 students in a subject outside my primary field, building the syllabus, lecture content, and all assessments.
- Administered homework and weekly quizzes through Pearson MyLab and Canvas; coordinated a teaching assistant for review sessions and grading.
- Opened units with current events (the 2008 housing bubble, tariffs); students cited the real-world applications as a strength in course evaluations.

Teaching Assistant, Iowa State University

ECON 1020: Principles of Macroeconomics — Spring 2026, Fall 2023
ECON 2070: Quantitative Methods in Economic Analysis I — Fall 2025
ECON 3530: Money, Banking, and Financial Institutions — Fall 2024
ECON 1010: Principles of Microeconomics (lab and online sections) — Fall 2022 – Winter 2024

- Led recitations, weekly quantitative labs, and pre-exam review sessions across principles and intermediate courses; designed and graded quizzes and exams.
- Ran fully online and accelerated sections, including a one-month asynchronous course with recorded review sessions, live Q&A, and virtual office hours.
- Received a rating of 4.2 out of 5 as teaching assistant for ECON 3530 (Fall 2024, 15 evaluations).
- Earned a faculty observer's note for getting students to talk and answer questions in class (ECON 2070 lab, Fall 2025).

Teaching Assistant, Shiv Nadar University, India

Econometrics (graduate course) — Spring 2021
Logic and Scientific Methods (undergraduate course) — Fall 2018

- Tutored 20 graduate students and 30 undergraduates one-on-one; graded assignments.

Mentorship, Iowa State University

Graduate Mentor, "Saturday Morning Breakfast Club" — Spring 2023 – Present

- Mentor undergraduates through their own research projects in the department's weekly undergraduate research program: framing research questions, finding data sources, building datasets, and writing replicable Stata code.
- Coauthored a *Growth and Change* article with an undergraduate first author and an *Agricultural Policy Review* article with an undergraduate coauthor.

Tutor, Economics Help Room — Spring 2023 – Fall 2024

- Tutored undergraduates one-on-one in the department's drop-in tutoring center, across principles and intermediate courses.
- Received 15 student evaluations in Spring 2024, about twice the help-room average; ranked among the top 3 of 25 tutors in Fall 2024, with the top supervisor rating.

Honors and Awards

Selected Paper ($200 award), Agricultural and Applied Economics Association (AAEA) South Asia Section Graduate Student Symposium — 2026
First Place, USDA Agricultural Marketing Service and AAEA Local Food Economics Data Visualization Challenge — 2026

- "Mapping the Missing Market Pathways in U.S. Dairy Regions," with A. Basha and H. Lee (GitHub Repository); $1,200 first-place team prize and $1,200 in AAEA travel support.

Professional Service

Referee

Growth and Change — 2025
Journal of Development Effectiveness — 2025

Conferences

Discussant, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting — Nov 2026
Discussant, AAEA South Asia Section Graduate Student Symposium — Oct 2026

Session Moderator, Agricultural & Applied Economics Association Annual Meeting — Jul 2026
Discussant, Midwest Economics Association Annual Meeting — Mar 2025

Iowa State University

Elected Chair, College of Liberal Arts and Sciences, Graduate & Professional Student Senate — 2023 – 2024
Senator, Department of Economics, Graduate & Professional Student Senate — 2023 – 2024

Professional Development

Mentee, Association for Mentoring and Inclusion in Economics (AMIE) — 2025 – 2026
Preparing Future Faculty Program, Iowa State University — Fall 2025

Professional Memberships

American Economic Association; Agricultural & Applied Economics Association; Midwest Economics Association

Core Competencies

Software: Stata, Python, LaTeX, Google Maps API (geocoding)
Data: IPUMS (CPS, ACS, Census), USDA Census of Agriculture, Department of Labor H-2A records, Iowa State University Alumni Survey, India's National Sample Survey and District Information System for Education
Restricted Data: Special Sworn Status, U.S. Census Bureau; Federal Statistical Research Data Center project No. 3044 (restricted American Community Survey and Numident microdata)
Methods: Panel data, difference-in-differences, shift-share (Bartik) instrumental variables, event study, regression discontinuity, randomized controlled trial design and evaluation
Additional Training: Machine Learning: A Signal Processing Perspective (EE 425)
Transferable Skills: Causal inference; program evaluation; survey data management; administrative data; data visualization; policy writing; research team supervision; research mentoring; course design
Languages: English (fluent), Hindi (native)

References

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